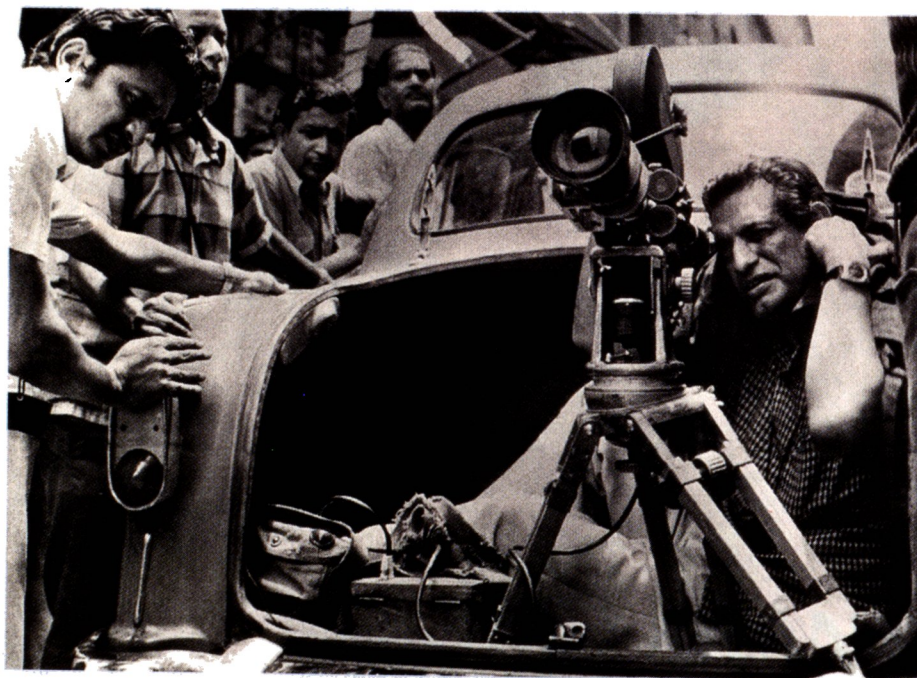




Q: Which Ray film did the state fund for "road improvement"?

A: *Pather Panchali*, in 1955

Q: Which film did Ray say was inspired by his story *The Alien*?

A: Steven Spielberg's *E.T.*, in 1982

Q: For which filmmaking duo's debut did he compose music?

A: Ismail Merchant and James Ivory

Q: Who was his 1972 documentary *Inner Eye* a tribute to?

A: His art teacher Binode B. Mukherjee

Q: On whose stories was his film *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne* based?

A: Grandfather Upendra Roy Chowdhury

had a secretary, and did everything himself, from writing letters to picking up the phone.

Mornings would also be reserved for illustrations, because he wanted to take advantage of the light. After lunch, he would concentrate on scripting, or music or any other thing that required his attention. Baba worked on every detail in his film, from the screenplay and costumes to the music and illustration of credits. I always saw him working. He would often work late into the night, and needed only four to five hours of sleep to carry on the next day.

But the one thing that he never compromised on was our lunches and dinners. Baba would insist we take them together, every member of the family present without fail. And that is where we exchanged notes, ideas and told each other about interesting things in our lives. Then, there were the Sunday morning *adda* sessions, which comprised not only film industry people but also relatives

and friends and colleagues from his old ad agency D.J. Keymer.

He never helped me with my studies, unless I asked him to, but he taught me so much else. He never ever insisted I had to be a filmmaker. But as I was growing up, I started sharing his interests. We were like friends. He asked me to read what other filmmakers had to say about the craft and told me to watch both good films and bad—good films for inspiration and bad films to know what not to do.

As a filmmaker, there was a certain ruthlessness about him. Sometimes, he would spend days working hard to put a scene together. But on the editing table, if he found that the scene was not taking the story forward, he would chop off the entire roll, not caring about how difficult it had been to put it together. The film had to be compact and every scene had to take the story forward. There were other

things that I learnt from him such as grammar and technique. I started by being a still photographer, and observing him helped me a lot, from exposure to the composition of frames. When I got interested in the technicalities of moviemaking, Baba and his unit members would patiently explain every aspect that befuddled me.

Receiving the Oscar for life-time achievement was a happy moment for him. In his acceptance speech, he mentioned how he had written to director Billy Wilder, after watching his 1944 film *Double Indemnity*, and how crestfallen he was when he didn't receive a reply. After that speech, Wilder sent him a telegram apologising for not responding, and promised that the next time Baba was in the US, they would sit and discuss *Double Indemnity* at length. Sadly, that never came to be.

As told to Swagata Sen

The writer is a filmmaker and the son of Satyajit Ray